



NCL Encore — Vancouver to LA Solo Group

October 12 – 18, 2026 · Allison Fishhead Burbank, host

Ship: Norwegian Encore · **Sailing from:** Canada Place, Vancouver · **Cabin:** _____

A condensed Voyage Pack from [In the Wake](#) — the essentials in three pages. The full pack covers cabins, packing, budget, ship orientation, ports in depth, NCL's quirks, and the group rhythm.

Day by day

#	Date	Port	Hours ashore	Dock	The one thing
1	Mon Oct 12	Vancouver, BC — embarkation + overnight in port	board 11:00 AM – 4:00 PM; ship stays overnight	Canada Place	All-aboard 4:30 PM. Go ashore for dinner — Gastown or Yaletown, return by 11:30 PM.
2	Tue Oct 13	Depart Vancouver + transit	morning departure (verify)	—	Lions Gate Bridge passage on the way out — be on Deck 15 fwd or Deck 8 Waterfront.
3	Wed Oct 14	Victoria, BC	~8:00 AM – 6:00 PM	Ogden Point + shuttle	Inner Harbour walk + Parliament tour. Butchart Gardens ~\$60 + transport if you commit.
4	Thu Oct 15	Cruising at sea (Pacific Coast)	—	—	Real Pacific transit day. Bonine the morning of if you're prone. Sea-day priorities below.
5	Fri Oct 16	San Francisco — arrive + overnight in port	arrive ~9 AM – 12 PM; overnight Fri–Sat	Pier 27 (Embarcadero)	Golden Gate at dawn if Captain announces approach. Then full day + night in SF.
6	Sat Oct 17	Depart San Francisco	morning in SF; depart 5:00–6:30 PM evening	—	Ferry Building farmers market 8 AM – 2 PM. Golden Gate at sunset if departure aligns.
7	Sun Oct 18	Los Angeles — debarkation	off by 10:30 AM	World Cruise Center, San Pedro	Uber to LAX \$40–55, 30–45 min. LAX TSA Sunday afternoons are rough — give margin.

TWO overnights in port — one in Vancouver (Mon night), one in San Francisco (Fri night). The big difference from a regular cruise: you get the cities at night.

Passport required — Canada is a foreign country for US citizens.

Currency aboard: USD. **Auto-gratuity:** \$20/day per person at most cabins; \$25/day Suites/Haven.

Decide before you board. Run the [drink-calculator](#) on your real drinking pattern, the [budget-calculator](#) for the total-fare picture, and the [tipping-calculator](#) for auto-grats + cash tips — mid-sail upgrades cost more per day and on a 6-night cruise you have very few days to break even. Tina can confirm what's bundled in Free at Sea.

Getting to the ship — and getting home

Arrival: Sunday recommended, Monday required

Sunday Oct 11 — fly into Vancouver (YVR). Same-day Monday flights to a 4:00 PM all-aboard are risky given border-crossing or YVR weather delays. Pre-cruise hotel in downtown / Coal Harbour / Gastown / Yaletown puts you walking distance to Canada Place.

Monday Oct 12 — embarkation.

- **Terminal: Canada Place** — the white sail-roofed downtown terminal.
- **YVR → Canada Place:** Taxi flat-rate ~CA\$35–45, 30–40 min. **Canada Line SkyTrain** ~CA\$10, 30 min (transfer at Waterfront Station, 5-min walk to terminal).
- **From Seattle:** Quick Coach / Quick Shuttle ~\$60–75 USD, 4 hours. Border can run 30–90 min on cruise day.
- **Embark window:** 11:00 AM – 4:00 PM. **All-aboard 4:30 PM.** Ship stays overnight in Vancouver.
- **NCL online check-in via the NCL app** before arrival.

Day 7 debark and the trip home

- **The night before:** bags in the hall by ~11 PM with color-coded tag.
- **6:00 – 8:00 AM:** Breakfast at Garden Café or The Local.
- **6:30 AM:** Customs clearance complete. Self-disembarkation begins.
- **7:00 – 10:00 AM:** Walk-off in waves. All passengers off by 10:30 AM.

Carry-on with you: change of clothes, all medications, passport, phone charger, valuables.

Getting from San Pedro / World Cruise Center to LAX: Uber/Lyft **\$40–55, 30–45 minutes** (traffic-dependent). Karmel Shuttle (port-to-LAX) ~\$25/person with advance booking. **Long Beach Airport (LGB)** is \$20–30 Uber, 15 min — smaller but quieter.

Killing 4–6 hours before an evening flight:

- **Battleship USS Iowa Museum** — 10-min walk from the terminal. \$25 entry, ~90 minutes.
- **San Pedro Fish Market** — 15-min Uber. Massive seafood market + restaurant.
- **Manhattan Beach / Hermosa Beach** — 30-min Uber. Classic SoCal beach towns.

Airport-arrival timing for LAX:

Flight	Leave San Pedro by
Domestic, after 3 PM	11:30 AM
International, after 6 PM	1:30 PM

LAX TSA on Sunday afternoons runs 30–90 min. Build margin.

Areas of interest during the cruise

On the ship — Encore spots worth knowing

- **Observation Lounge** (Deck 15 forward) — heated, glass-roofed, panoramic. The trip's best 30 minutes are sunrise here (Pacific sunrise off port; ocean stretching to horizon off starboard).
- **Manhattan Room** (Deck 7 aft) — main dining room with live music most evenings. Most atmospheric of the included rooms.
- **The three-deck race track** at the aft — the original go-kart track at sea. Paid (~\$15/race). First hour after opening empty.
- **Aqua Park** with Aqua Racer (twin slides, race a friend) and Ocean Loops (the loop slide). Both free.
- **Vibe Beach Club** — adults-only with private pool. \$99/day or \$399/week pre-cruise.
- **Galaxy Pavilion** — VR + immersive games arcade. Paid per experience.
- **Studio Lounge** (solo-cabin perk) — hosted coffee hour Day 2 morning typically.
- **The Cavern Club** — Beatles tribute most nights (verify it's still running).

Sea-day priorities (Day 4 — Thursday)

1. **Sunrise on the Observation Lounge** — Pacific to the horizon. Best 30 minutes of the week.
2. **Bonine the morning** of if you're prone to motion — real Pacific swells possible.
3. **The race track + Galaxy Pavilion first hour** they open — empty.
4. **Mandara Spa thermal suite** — sea-day intro rate.
5. **Port talk for San Francisco** — knows the Golden Gate approach timing.

Specialty dining picks

- **Cagney's Steakhouse** — celebration meal; reliably good.
- **Le Bistro** — French; the most romantic specialty.
- **Food Republic** — pan-Asian small plates; the most distinctive room on Encore.
- **Teppanyaki** — hibachi; group-friendly round tables.
- **Q Texas Smokehouse** — Texas BBQ.

Port-day picks (one each)

- **Vancouver (overnight)** — go ashore for dinner. Gastown or Yaletown (10–15 min walk). Or do a 7 AM walk through Stanley Park before the ship gets moving.
- **Victoria, BC** — Inner Harbour walk + Parliament tour (free). Or commit to Butchart Gardens (~\$60 + ~\$60–75 transport, 3–4 hours total).
- **San Francisco (overnight)** — Golden Gate at dawn or sunset if timing aligns. Friday night dinner in the city. Saturday morning Ferry Building farmers market 8 AM – 2 PM.

The two photogenic bridge passages

- **Lions Gate Bridge** (Vancouver) — Tuesday morning/afternoon as the ship departs. Suspension bridge, ~60 ft clearance for Encore. Stanley Park to port.
- **Golden Gate Bridge** (San Francisco) — Friday morning approach and/or Saturday evening departure. Best photograph at sunset.

Where Allison sets the rhythm

- **Day 1 settle-in** — likely Observation Lounge or one of the bars. Watch her communications.
- **Group dinners** — Allison typically books one or two specialty group nights (Cagney's, Le Bistro, or Food Republic). RSVP early.
- **Studio Lounge** — solo cruisers cluster here regardless of who's hosting.

Photo spots worth knowing

- **Sailaway from Observation Lounge** — Vancouver skyline + Coast Mountains at dawn (Mon overnight or Tue departure).
- **Lions Gate Bridge passage** — Stanley Park on port; Vancouver skyline behind.
- **Golden Gate approach at dawn** — fog optional but signature.
- **Victoria Parliament Buildings illuminated** — late afternoon as ship departs.
- **Golden Gate from departing San Francisco** at sunset — the trip's most spectacular photograph if timing aligns.

Need an at-home emergency handoff card? Separate one-page doc — ask Allison/Tina or download from [In the Wake](#). The full Voyage Pack is the unabridged companion document. Soli Deo Gloria.